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Narcissism: Detriment to Woman, Empowerment to Man

In Simone de Beauvoir's chapter on "The Independent Woman" in *The Second Sex*, Beauvoir proposes the idea that, "Instead of enriching the woman, her narcissism impoverishes her" (de Beauvoir, 839). Today, we often characterize a narcissistic or prideful person as someone who awards themself excessive self-importance or has high self-esteem. Simone Beauvoir does not see pride and narcissism as synonymous and emphasizes these words' respective positive and negative connotations by exposing their connections to gender: "phallic pride" versus a woman's narcissism. This distinction is connected to a broader comparison Beauvoir makes between woman and man: their respective existences as immanent and transcendent. Instead of empowering and increasing a woman's status in society, her narcissism augments the objectification of herself which is created by her imprisonment in the realm of immanence. The subject of her narcissism is woman as an object, not her woman as a human being. She is closed off from contributing to the external world, and, in turn, her equality to man in society diminishes. On the other hand, any self-admiration a man bestows upon himself is described as phallic pride. This explicit denotation of pride as masculine, or related to the phallus, stems from man's ability to transcend, externalize himself in his phallus, and find himself in the world. This offers man's pride a more positive, empowering connotation than woman's narcissism. Ultimately, self-admiration aims to augment and display approval of one's sense of self; under Beauvoir's view that woman's self is constituted by her entrapment in the

realm of immanence and that man's self is constituted by his ability to transcend, this augmentation impacts man and woman in opposite ways: for the man, the transcendence that makes him feel free in society is reinforced, and for the woman, her immanence is reinforced, further entrapping her as an object and limiting her significance and freedom in society.

To understand why a woman's narcissism is a detriment whereas a man's pride reinforces his freedom, we must first look at what about the man's self, according to Beauvoir, is different from the woman's: man's designation as transcendent. In *The Second Sex*, Beauvoir adopts the perspective of existentialist morality. One of the central claims of this existentialist infrastructure is that existence precedes essence. We can see the influence this has on Beeauvoir's writing in her opening to her chapter on childhood: "One is not born, but rather becomes, woman" (331). The broader existentialist idea she is pointing to here is that humans, which she occasionally refers to as existents, take on projects that aid their transcendence or achievement of freedom. One project that aids transcendence is the ability to alienate oneself in an object to validate and solidify their place in the world. Beauvoir points out that a biological difference between male and female beings, the male's phallus being able to be held and seen outside of the body in comparison to a woman's genitals which reside somewhat "inside" her, bestows upon men the ability to alienate part of himself in his penis in childhood. This externalization of the man in his penis, a project that aids his transcendence and secures his sense of being in the world, ties transcendence to masculinity and man's physical form: "the very object in which he alienates himself becomes a symbol of autonomy, transcendence, and power" (340). Transcendence, a way for humans to justify their existence is then seen as a masculine endeavor. This now-gendered aspect of transcendence makes it easier for man to justify his existence and feel free in the world. His destiny as a man is synonymous with freedom and transcendence and he is empowered to

live his life as a man because his penis alone can grant him transcendence. As he grows older, “Usually he works outside the home, and it is through him that the household communicates with the rest of the world: he is the embodiment of this adventurous, immense, difficult, and marvelous world; he is transcendence, he is God” (349). A man’s self - autonomous, powerful, adventurous - is constituted by his penis; his possession of his phallus awards him an air of superiority compared to those without a phallus and, in turn, he others the female.

Women lacking a penis, biological females in the context of Beauvoir’s writings, suffer from this masculine designation of transcendence and are therefore othered and pushed into the realm of immanence; furthermore, this woman’s project towards achieving transcendence, attempting to externalize herself in the world, fails without a phallus, causing her objectification. Beauvoir explains the impacts of women lacking an object with the same advantage, being both external and internal to the body, of a phallus: “Deprived of this alter ego, the little girl does not alienate herself in a graspable thing, does not reclaim herself: she is thus led to make her entire self an object, to posit herself as the Other" (82). The woman becomes an object instead of a subject and her path to realizing herself as a free human being rather than just an existent or body becomes more difficult. She is forced to submit to men’s designation of women as the “Other” - a designation that aids men's transcendence and makes men feel superior in society. This imposed recognition of a woman's othering is said to “doom her to immanence” (37). While all humans ideally recognize their immanence and transcendence, there is a conflict for the woman: transcendence is associated with the biological male, and any attempts at achieving transcendence on her part are seen as a “masculine protest” (85). It seems as though, for a woman to transcend, she must deny her womanhood, but women are often scrutinized for lacking femininity or rejecting their womanhood. These obstacles present for a woman’s transcendence

make her fall into immanence which creates a “degradation of existence into ‘in-itself’...tak[ing] the form of frustration and oppression” (37). This characterization of immanence as existence degrading inwards is important for explaining woman’s condition in the realm of immanence. For the woman, living in immanence means she cannot find herself in the world. She exists only within her body, which she has been forced to make an object. The woman, in turn, immerses herself in the object of her body, an image, rather than her future or the impact she has on the external world. She believes her authority rules over only her objectified body rather than any part of society. The first thing Beauvoir lists when explaining ways in which a woman asserts her femininity is “dressing up” (830). Beauvoir consistently links how a woman feels she must behave in society to her appearance: “She has to be white like an ermine… dressed in vaporous organdy, her room is decorated”, “she has to be ‘pretty as a picture’; she tries to resemble an image… she looks at herself in the mirror, she compares herself to princesses and fairies from tales” (385, 340). The woman looking in the mirror to compare herself to characters from a tale is a particularly striking account because it exposes that a woman does not compare her character or morals to the heroes or heroines in fairy tales, but instead judges her reflection; she does not feel that her self is constituted by her mind or intellectual capability, instead, she believes she is constituted by the image of herself that is presented to society. This constitution of self-defined by a woman’s immanence awards women little authority over themselves: the woman does not create images, she is defined by them meaning she is dependent on society’s opinions regarding what is pretty or feminine: “she needs a gaze from above to reveal and consecrate her worth” (828). It is this idea, that a woman’s immanence traps her sense of self in an object, that makes the effects of a woman’s self-adoration different from a man’s.

Self-admiration is, simply put, an appreciation of one's self. The problem for the woman, then, and what makes her pleasure or appreciation of herself narcissism, is that she is appreciating an image, the object of herself. On the other hand, the man is appreciating his self which consists of the power, autonomy, and adventurous spirit granted to him by his penis. Beauvoir explicitly calls the penis a "source of pride" from which "man can integrate into his personality the life that flows from it" (82). His appreciation for his self is an appreciation is, also an appreciation for his transcendence. And, if there exists a "fundamental project" for humans to transcend themselves "toward being", then the man's pride in his phallus, the object which lets him accomplish this project toward being, is justified and beneficial for his existence (94). Criticizing a man's pride in his biological maleness seems almost unfair if man believes that the general aim of living is transcendence towards being since the way he is told he can accomplish this aim is by the mere possession of his penis.

Women, on the other hand, when appreciating themself, are not justifying or admiring a part of themself that contributes to some greater project to establish themselves in the world as a "being". She appreciates something superficial about herself because she has been cast into the realm of immanence. Beauvoir notes that while women may want to strive to achieve this project for being, they fail: "she looks for the image of her soul in nature, she abandons herself to her reveries, she wants to reach her being: she is doomed to failure; she can only recover it in the realm of imagination" (836). Again, even as she searches to find herself in nature, to externalize herself in the world, to transcend, she is blocked by her immanence and objectification. Because she cannot find herself in the world, she has no choice but to live only in her mind, her imagination, and she becomes occupied by expressing only her feelings in social life through writing or poetry. Beauvoir seems to be saying that women's writings do not impact society

because the subject of her poetry, her immanent self, does not connect her to others in the world. As a result of her objectification of her own body, the woman is not a being in the world, she is an object in the world and a being only in her mind. The woman's lack of being in the world makes her appreciation of her own success in her adult life narcissism: "She would have had to be brought up exactly like a boy to be able to comfortably overcome adolescent narcissism: but in her adult life she perpetuates this cult of self toward which her whole youth has predisposed her; she uses the merits of her professional success to enrich her image" (828). Her work is defined by her immanence and can only express her feelings and situation, creating this cult of self; her professional endeavors are self-centered and, therefore, any pride she takes in her work seems selfish - her work means little for the progression of society. Furthermore, her pride is likely to be received negatively because it enriches something superficial, an image, which highlights a woman's immanence. Woman's inability to transcend means she is unable to look toward her future: "She only succeeds in accepting herself from the perspective of both the present and the past….She has cultivated narcissistic dreams; she continues to pit the cult of her image against the phallic pride of the male; she wants to show off, to charm" (817). Here Beauvoir is explicitly criticizing a woman's cult of image as narcissism in comparison to phallic pride. The phallic pride of a male seems to be an inherent part of the man while the cult of image of a woman seems to be an act, something she is cultivating to "show off, to charm". It's almost as if Beauvoir believes a woman's pride is an attempt to deceive society into thinking she is something she is not. After all, phallic pride is gendered masculine, so for a woman to be expressing any sort of pride, would be her rejecting her femininity, which, as previously mentioned, women are criticized for even today. Ultimately a woman's pride is not celebrated or encouraged the same way a man's can be because the woman's immanence and objectification

make the subject of her pride a superficial image with no meaning outside the women's mind whereas the man's pride empowers his transcendence, a fundamental project humans believe they should achieve.

Simone de Beauvoir concludes *The Second Sex* with a chapter titled "The Independent Woman" in which she claims that independent women suffer because of their inability to forget themselves. She attributes the hardships of the few successful women in art and literature in her time to an internal conflict in the woman between feelings of narcissism and inferiority. The inferiority is created by the othering and immanence she is subjected to by man's transcendence and the narcissism is also a product of her immanence - it is the only way her immanence can allow her to feel successful. Beauvoir continues by explaining, "Not being able to forget oneself is a failure that will weigh on them… if their essential goal is an abstract self-affirmation, the formal satisfaction of success, they will not abandon themselves to the contemplation of the world" (838). Not only is a woman's narcissism created by her immanence, but it also reinforces her lack of connection to the world, further impoverishing her ability to transcend. It may seem as though I am arguing that a woman should stray away from feeling prideful or appreciative of her accomplishments, but it is important to remember that these conditions are created because of the Other status awarded to the woman by man. For this to change, society must shift to alter the gendering of the transcendence project and reject preaching masculine and feminine values in childhood.

Works Cited

De Beauvoir, Simone. *The Second Sex*. Translated by Constance Borde and Sheila Malovany-Chevallier, *Vintage Books*, 2011.